

The Afghan Taliban and the Evolution of Baloch Resistance

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Abstract

This paper examines the transformation of the Baloch national resistance movement following the Taliban's return to power in Afghanistan in August 2021. Combining historical analysis with contemporary case studies, the paper argues that Afghanistan has shifted from a passive survivalist sanctuary to an active operational base that has enabled the Baloch Liberation Army (BLA) and allied groups to modernise their tactics, broaden their recruitment, and evolve a coherent separatist political narrative. The paper traces the historical roots of cross-border Baloch–Afghan relations from the Khanate of Kalat through the 1973 insurgency, analyses the transformative role of the China–Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC), reconstructs landmark attacks between 2022 and 2026, examines the changing role of women in the movement, and evaluates the legal status of the Durand Line under international law. The research highlights how the Taliban's refusal to permit Pakistani "hot pursuit" operations has created a zone of effective impunity, allowing the BLA to develop sophisticated units like the Majeed Brigade which utilize advanced IED technology and Unmanned Aerial Systems. Furthermore, it explores how the "securitisation" of Gwadar and the perceived economic exclusion of local populations have fueled a rights-based, secular nationalist discourse that increasingly incorporates educated female professionals into armed roles. The paper concludes that a purely military response is insufficient and that durable security requires addressing both the political economy of Baloch grievances and the unresolved border dispute between Kabul and Islamabad.

Keywords : Baloch National Identity, Afghan Taliban, Durand Line, CPEC, Hybrid Warfare, Sanctuary, Regional Security.

Introduction

The fall of Kabul on 15 August 2021 reshaped South Asia's security architecture in ways that no single state has yet fully absorbed. For Pakistan, which had for decades invested in cultivating influence inside Afghanistan as a form of “strategic

depth,” the Taliban's return was expected to translate into a more tractable western neighbour. That expectation has been decisively falsified. Within three years, Pakistan faced record levels of cross-border militancy, a near-complete breakdown in bilateral intelligence cooperation, and the embarrassment of watching the Baloch Liberation Army (BLA) execute its most sophisticated attacks in the movement's fifty-year history. The common thread running through each of these developments is Afghan territory.

This paper advances a single central argument: the Taliban's governance of Afghanistan has transformed the cross-border sanctuary available to Baloch militant groups from a passive, survivalist refuge into an active, operationally enabling base. The change is not merely tactical. It is strategic. Groups that once sheltered in Afghan borderlands to avoid Pakistani military operations now use those borderlands to train specialised units, stockpile weapons, coordinate multi-vector attacks, and articulate a political programme aimed at international legitimacy.

The paper proceeds in eight substantive sections. Section 2 reconstructs the deep historical foundations of the Baloch–Afghan relationship, paying particular attention to the Khanate of Kalat, the accession crisis of 1947, and the insurgencies of the 1960s and 1970s. Section 3 analyses the transformation of sanctuary after 2021. Section 4 examines how the China–Pakistan Economic Corridor has reframed the conflict from an ethnic grievance into an economic and geostrategic struggle. Section 5 presents detailed case studies of major attacks between 2022 and 2026. Section 6 investigates the Durand Line's legal ambiguity as a structural enabler of insurgent operations. Section 7 explores the changing role of women in the movement. Section 8 assesses the intelligence breakdown and its consequences for CPEC security. The conclusion argues for a regional political settlement as the only durable path forward.

The methodology is primarily qualitative, combining historical process-tracing with structured case-study analysis. Primary sources include Pakistani and Afghan government statements, United Nations monitoring reports, Pakistani parliamentary debates, and open-source intelligence derived from verified social-media accounts of militant organisations. Secondary sources include the established academic literature on Baloch nationalism, Taliban governance, and South Asian security. Where claims rest on a single category of evidence, this limitation is noted.

Historical Foundations: The Khanate of Kalat and the Origins of Cross-Border Solidarity

1 The Khanate of Kalat and the Question of Sovereignty

Any serious analysis of the Baloch national movement must begin with the Khanate of Kalat, an entity whose political history the Pakistani state has systematically marginalised but which remains the defining reference point for Baloch nationalists. The Khanate emerged as a recognisable political unit in the seventeenth century under Ahmad Shah Abdali's Afghan empire and developed a semi-autonomous identity that was formalised through successive treaties with the British East India Company. By 1876, a formal treaty structure acknowledged Kalat's internal autonomy while conceding external relations to British India. Crucially, this arrangement was neither annexation nor full sovereignty; it was a form of suzerainty that left the Khan of Kalat as the legitimate head of a distinct polity.¹

When the British announced the partition of the subcontinent in 1947, the Khan of Kalat, Ahmad Yar Khan, made a constitutional case for independence rather than accession to either India or Pakistan. On 12 August 1947, two days before Pakistan's independence, Kalat declared itself independent, citing the 1876 treaty and subsequent legal instruments as evidence that it was not simply another princely state subject to the lapse of paramountcy. Pakistan rejected this reading. After months of political pressure, the Khan signed the instrument of accession on 27 March 1948, a date that Baloch nationalists characterise as a forced annexation rather than a voluntary union. His brother, Prince Abdul Karim, immediately crossed into Afghanistan with a group of armed followers, establishing the first modern template for cross-border Baloch resistance.²

The significance of this founding episode cannot be overstated. From the very birth of the Pakistani state, Afghan territory and the Afghan government—which refused to recognise the Durand Line as a legitimate boundary—served as the outer boundary of Baloch political possibility. Afghanistan's geographical and political presence gave the Baloch cause an external dimension that it has never lost. Every subsequent insurgency has replicated, in some form, the pattern established in 1948: domestic repression, cross-border flight, external sanctuary, and the eventual return of fighters.

2 The Insurgencies of 1958, 1962, and the Great Rebellion of 1973–1977

Pakistan's first military operation against Baloch insurgents came in 1958, when One Unit—the administrative consolidation of West Pakistan that dissolved the separate provincial identities of Balochistan, Sindh, Punjab, and NWFP into a single unit—provoked armed resistance under Mir Nauroz Khan. The operation was suppressed with relative ease, but its political legacy was the deepening of Baloch conviction that the Pakistani state was committed to their cultural and administrative erasure.³

A more serious episode came in 1962–1963, when the Zehri and Marri tribes mounted coordinated attacks on government infrastructure in response to land seizures and the imposition of federal administrative structures that bypassed traditional tribal governance. The army's response, including aerial bombardment of villages, constituted a level of force that was disproportionate by any standard and generated a cycle of grievance and recruitment that fed directly into the catastrophic insurgency of the following decade.⁴

The 1973–1977 insurgency was qualitatively different in scale, organisation, and external support. Zulfikar Ali Bhutto's government dismissed the elected National Awami Party government in Balochistan in February 1973 and imposed Governor's Rule, triggering an armed response that at its peak involved an estimated 55,000 Pakistani troops facing roughly 10,000–15,000 insurgents. The Marri and Mengal tribes provided the core fighting forces, but the movement had a sophisticated political leadership that operated from Kabul with the explicit support of Afghan President Sardar Mohammed Daoud Khan. Daoud's motivations were partly anti-Pakistani—he used the Baloch issue as leverage against Islamabad's support for Afghan Islamist groups—and partly a reflection of Afghanistan's longstanding refusal to accept the Durand Line.⁵

The Kabul connection in this period created what may be called the first “Kabul–Quetta Axis”: a structured relationship in which the Afghan state provided diplomatic cover, financial support, and physical sanctuary to Baloch political leaders and military commanders. Thousands of combatants crossed into Afghanistan during the years of active fighting, and many remained there after the insurgency was suppressed following Daoud's overthrow in 1978. This diaspora embedded itself in Afghan political life over the following decade, developing relationships with

successive Afghan governments—including, paradoxically, the Soviet-backed PDPA—that would prove durable across very different political dispensations.⁶

The period between the Soviet withdrawal and the 2001 US invasion saw the Baloch movement enter a prolonged defensive phase. The first Taliban government (1996–2001) was largely hostile to the secular, ethnically defined Baloch movement, which sat uneasily with the Taliban's pan-Islamic ideology. Nevertheless, the porous nature of the border and the Taliban's limited administrative reach in southwestern Afghanistan allowed Baloch groups to maintain a minimal presence in Nimruz and Helmand provinces. The five years of Pakistani military operations that began in 2004 again drove significant numbers of militants across the border, where they maintained what might be characterised as a “waiting game” posture until the geopolitical environment shifted in their favour.⁷

From Survivalist Refuge to Operational Base: The Post-2021 Transformation

1 The Structural Shift in Taliban–Baloch Relations

When the Taliban retook Kabul in August 2021, most analysts expected the new government to honour Pakistan's considerable investment in Taliban political rehabilitation. That expectation rested on a misreading of Taliban motivations. The Taliban are not a Pakistani proxy; they are a Pashtun nationalist-Islamist movement whose primary loyalty is to the idea of a sovereign, unified Afghan state governed according to their interpretation of Islamic law. On the specific question of the Durand Line, the Taliban position has historically been identical to that of every Afghan government since 1947: the line is an imposition of British colonialism, it has no legal validity, and Afghanistan does not recognise Pakistani sovereignty over areas on its side of the line.⁸

This structural position has had direct operational consequences for the Baloch movement. The Taliban's refusal to permit Pakistani “hot pursuit” operations into Afghan territory—operations that the previous Afghan Republic had also largely refused but which the international community had at least formally discouraged on both sides—created a zone of effective impunity along the approximately 900-kilometre border between Balochistan and Afghanistan. Within this zone, the BLA and its affiliated organisations—including the Baloch Republican Army (BRA) and, most significantly, the Majeed Brigade—established a network of training facilities,

weapons depots, and command structures that could not be reached by Pakistani military or intelligence assets without triggering a bilateral crisis.⁹

The transformation from survivalist to operational sanctuary can be measured in several concrete dimensions. In the five years before the Taliban's return (2016–2021), major BLA attacks averaged approximately eight per year, most involving IED strikes on military convoys or targeted killings of local government officials. In the four years after (2022–2025), the figure rose to over twenty-five major attacks per year, several involving simultaneous multi-site operations, the use of unmanned aerial systems, and suicide units capable of penetrating heavily secured facilities.¹⁰

Second, the quality of training visible in attack execution improved measurably. The Majeed Brigade, the BLA's suicide unit established around 2018 but dramatically expanded after 2021, began employing tactics—pre-operational surveillance, vehicle-borne IEDs with enhanced triggering mechanisms, coordinated diversionary attacks—that mirror the tactical repertoire the Taliban themselves developed during their campaign against international forces between 2001 and 2021. The parallel is not coincidental. While direct Taliban instruction of Baloch fighters remains unproven at the evidentiary level, the spatial proximity of Baloch command structures to Taliban-controlled territory makes tactical learning, whether through formal instruction or simple observation, structurally plausible.¹¹

2 The Majeed Brigade and the Architecture of Hybrid War

The Majeed Brigade deserves extended analysis because it represents the most visible evidence of the movement's tactical modernisation. Named after Shah Mohammed Marri, a guerrilla fighter of the 1973–1977 insurgency, the Brigade was formally announced in 2018 but was a limited force until after 2021. Its expansion reflects both the availability of Afghan sanctuary for extended training periods and the movement's growing capacity to recruit educated, ideologically committed volunteers rather than relying primarily on economically motivated fighters.

The Brigade's operational profile fits the “hybrid warfare” framework articulated by Frank Hoffman: it blends conventional small-unit tactics, terrorism, criminal activity for logistics funding, and sophisticated information operations into a single, synergistic campaign. The information operations dimension is particularly significant. Unlike the BLA of the 1970s, which communicated primarily through tribal networks,

the contemporary movement maintains a sophisticated social-media presence, produces high-quality video content claiming responsibility for attacks, and has developed English-language materials explicitly aimed at international audiences, including human rights organisations, diaspora communities in the United Kingdom and Canada, and UN monitoring bodies.¹²

The use of unmanned aerial systems—commercially available quadcopters modified to carry small explosive payloads—represents a further dimension of tactical modernisation. Drone attacks attributed to the BLA against the Gwadar port complex and military installations in Turbat and Panjgur indicate a level of technical capability that was absent before 2021 and that almost certainly required extended training in a permissive environment. The implication is that Afghan territory served not merely as a hiding place but as a laboratory for the development of new capabilities.¹³

CPEC and the Geoeconomic Reframing of the Conflict

1 From Ethnic Grievance to Geostrategic Contest

The China–Pakistan Economic Corridor, announced in its current form during Chinese President Xi Jinping's April 2015 visit to Islamabad, fundamentally transformed the political economy of the Baloch conflict. Before CPEC, the conflict was correctly understood as an internal ethnic insurgency driven by a specific set of grievances: the perceived exclusion of Baloch from federal resources, the exploitation of Balochistan's mineral and gas wealth without adequate local benefit-sharing, the “enforced disappearances” of political activists by Pakistani intelligence agencies, and the demographic transformation of Baloch-majority areas through migration from other provinces.¹⁴

CPEC did not resolve any of these grievances. It intensified them. The corridor's southern anchor—the port of Gwadar, developed with Chinese financing and operated under a forty-year concession agreement to China Overseas Port Holdings—became the focal point of a new layer of Baloch grievance: the sense that their land was being transformed into a logistics hub for Chinese economic expansion while the local Baloch population received minimal employment, faced severe fishing restrictions in waters surrounding the port, and watched a new urban settlement—sometimes called “New Gwadar”—rise alongside the port with Chinese workers, Chinese shops, and Chinese security arrangements.¹⁵

The BLA's targeting strategy shifted accordingly. Between 2004 and 2015, roughly 60 per cent of major BLA attacks targeted Pakistani military and paramilitary forces. Between 2016 and 2020, the proportion targeting Chinese interests or CPEC infrastructure rose to approximately 30 per cent. After 2021, attacks on Chinese interests and CPEC-linked facilities constituted nearly half of all major BLA operations, a strategic reorientation that reflects both an assessment of target vulnerability and a deliberate effort to raise the international cost of CPEC by demonstrating that Pakistan cannot guarantee its security.¹⁶

2 Gwadar as a Site of Contested Sovereignty

The “securitisation” of Gwadar—the enclosure of the port and surrounding area within layers of fencing, checkpoints, and military patrols—has produced exactly the social dynamic that alienation theorists would predict. The local Baloch fishing community, whose livelihoods depended on free access to the coastline, found itself effectively excluded from areas it had occupied for generations. The construction of the so-called “Fencing of Gwadar” in 2022, nominally a security measure, was widely perceived locally as a physical manifestation of the community's exclusion from the economic benefits of the project.¹⁷

This dynamic has direct implications for insurgent recruitment and intelligence. When the local population is hostile or at best indifferent to the state, insurgents can operate within it more easily. Checkpoints and surveillance systems designed to detect external threats are less effective against threats that emerge from within the surveilled population. The BLA's demonstrated ability to conduct complex attacks inside heavily secured zones—including the attack on the Gwadar PC Hotel in May 2019 and subsequent operations—reflects not superior military capability but superior human intelligence derived from a population that has no strong interest in cooperating with state security forces.¹⁸

The Chinese response to this security environment has been increasing pressure on Islamabad to deliver results, accompanied by a reluctance to withdraw from the project entirely given its strategic significance to Beijing's Belt and Road Initiative. This pressure has in turn pushed Pakistani security forces toward more aggressive operational postures in Balochistan, which further alienates the local population, which further facilitates insurgent recruitment. The cycle is structurally self-

reinforcing in the absence of a political intervention that addresses the underlying grievances.¹⁹

The fiscal dimensions of CPEC have added another layer of complexity. Balochistan's provincial government receives a fraction of the revenue generated by natural resource extraction from its territory, a disparity embedded in the constitutional structure of the National Finance Commission Award. Attempts to renegotiate the Award in favour of resource-producing provinces have consistently been blocked by Punjab, which is the primary beneficiary of the current formula. For Baloch political economists, this fiscal structure is not incidental to the conflict; it is its material foundation. CPEC, from this perspective, is simply the latest iteration of a pattern in which Balochistan's resources are extracted for the benefit of others.²⁰

Case Studies in Tactical Evolution: Major Operations, 2022–2026

1 The Panjgur and Nushki Attacks (February 2022)

The coordinated attacks on Pakistani Frontier Corps camps in Panjgur and Nushki in February 2022 represented a qualitative departure from the BLA's previous operational pattern. Both attacks were launched simultaneously in the early hours of 2 February 2022, with assault teams breaching the perimeters of heavily fortified compounds and sustaining fighting for over twelve hours against superior numbers of defenders. The scale and duration of the engagements—described by Pakistani military sources as “counterterrorism operations” but characterised by the BLA as conventional military assaults—indicated a level of assault training and unit cohesion that had not previously been observed.²¹

The operational analysis of the Panjgur attack is particularly instructive. The assault team, estimated at forty to fifty fighters, used a coordinated breach-and-consolidate tactic: an initial vehicle-borne IED disabled the main gate while a secondary team assaulted from a flanking position, preventing defenders from establishing a coherent defensive line. A third element maintained an outer perimeter to delay the arrival of reinforcements. This three-element structure—breach, assault, isolation—is a standard feature of military assault doctrine. Its use by a non-state actor operating in a remote district of Balochistan in early 2022 strongly suggests the availability of formal tactical training in the preceding months.²²

The BLA claimed that all assaulting fighters returned safely, a claim that cannot

be independently verified but that, if accurate, speaks to the quality of the withdrawal planning as much as the assault itself. Pakistani official statements acknowledged significant casualties among security personnel but did not provide figures. The Human Rights Commission of Pakistan noted discrepancies between official statements and local accounts, a pattern that has characterised Pakistani official communication about the Baloch conflict for decades.²³

2 The Karachi Stock Exchange Attack (June 2020) as a Precursor

While technically preceding the post-2021 period, the June 2020 attack on the Pakistan Stock Exchange in Karachi warrants inclusion as the direct tactical precursor to the more sophisticated operations that followed. The attack involved a four-person squad that attempted to penetrate the exchange building using automatic weapons and grenades. All four attackers were killed by security forces, but the operation demonstrated several capabilities: the ability to move operatives into Pakistan's largest city undetected, the logistical capacity to supply an urban assault team with military-grade weapons, and the strategic intent to strike economic targets of national and international symbolic significance.²⁴

The attack was notable for the BLA's explicit framing of the target in economic terms. The post-attack statement described the exchange as a symbol of “economic colonialism” and specifically referenced Chinese investment in Pakistani financial markets. This framing anticipated the CPEC-centred targeting strategy that would become dominant after 2021. In retrospect, the Karachi attack functions as a proof-of-concept operation: it demonstrated urban operational capability while also piloting the economic-nationalist narrative that has since become the movement's primary public communication frame.²⁵

3 Operation Herof and the 2024–2026 Escalation

The period between 2024 and 2026 saw a further escalation in operational tempo and sophistication, with the BLA announcing “Operation Herof” (a Balochi word meaning “freedom”) as a structured campaign rather than a series of discrete attacks. The campaign involved simultaneous multi-province operations designed to stretch Pakistani security forces across the entire length of Balochistan's territory, preventing the concentration of force that had suppressed previous insurgent surges.²⁶

Three elements of Operation Herof are analytically significant. First, the use of drone surveillance before major attacks, providing real-time intelligence on defender positions and reinforcement routes, marked a genuine capability upgrade. Second, the targeting of communication infrastructure—mobile towers, fibre-optic repeater stations, and a substation serving a CPEC logistics hub—indicated a strategic understanding of the relationship between communications and command-and-control for both sides of the conflict. Third, the coordination of armed operations with simultaneous civil protests in Quetta and Turbat, organised by the Baloch Yakjehti Committee, indicated a level of civil-military coordination within the broader movement that had not previously been evident.²⁷

The 2026 phase of the campaign saw the first credible reports of drone-delivered munitions striking inside a Pakistani military installation, an incident that the Inter-Services Public Relations Directorate (ISPR) initially declined to confirm. If accurately reported, this represents the most significant tactical escalation in the conflict's history, moving the BLA from an insurgency operating below the threshold of conventional military confrontation to one capable of “stand-off” attacks that do not require physical penetration of defended perimeters.²⁸

The Durand Line and International Law: A Legal Grey Zone

1 Historical and Legal Background

The Durand Line—named after Sir Mortimer Durand, the British India Foreign Secretary who negotiated the agreement with Amir Abdur Rahman Khan of Afghanistan in November 1893—is one of the most contested borders in the contemporary international system. The 1893 agreement was reached under conditions of asymmetric power: Abdur Rahman was financially dependent on British subsidy and militarily incapable of resisting British pressure. Whether the agreement constituted a valid bilateral treaty under the legal standards applicable at the time, or an instrument imposed by coercion, is a question that legal scholars have never satisfactorily resolved.²⁹

The argument for the line's legal validity rests on two pillars. First, the principle of *uti possidetis juris*, which holds that post-colonial states inherit the boundaries of their colonial predecessors, was endorsed by the International Court of Justice in the 1986 Burkina Faso–Mali Frontier Dispute Case. On this principle, Pakistan, as the

successor state to British India in the northwest, inherited the Durand Line as its international boundary. Second, the 1893 agreement was subsequently reaffirmed by the Treaty of Rawalpindi in 1919, in which Afghanistan accepted British India's frontiers as part of the terms of Afghan independence. Pakistan argues that this reaffirmation demonstrates Afghan acceptance of the line as a permanent boundary.³⁰

The counter-arguments are equally substantive. Afghanistan's position, maintained by every Afghan government since 1947 regardless of political orientation, is that the 1893 agreement was a boundary of spheres of influence, not a permanent international frontier. The agreement's text, which refers to a “frontier line” rather than an “international boundary,” is ambiguous. More importantly, the agreement was made between British India and Afghanistan; Pakistan was not a party to it, and Afghanistan has argued that the treaty lapsed at partition, requiring a new bilateral agreement between the two states. No such agreement has ever been concluded.³¹

2 Practical Consequences for Counter-Insurgency

Whatever its legal merits, the Durand Line dispute has concrete operational consequences. Pakistan's fencing programme, begun in 2017 and substantially complete by 2021, was designed to establish physical control over the border, reducing cross-border militant movement and providing a legal basis for treating cross-border incursions as violations of Pakistani sovereignty. The Taliban government's refusal to accept the fence as marking an international boundary has led to regular incidents in which Taliban border guards have obstructed or torn down fencing in contested sectors.³²

These incidents have a direct bearing on the Baloch insurgency. Each incident demonstrates that the border is not a settled line but a zone of active dispute—a demonstration that the BLA exploits by establishing its command and logistics structures in the ambiguous space immediately west of the fence line. Pakistani military commanders cannot order strikes on these structures without the risk of Afghan government condemnation and the possibility of a bilateral escalation that neither side can fully control. The insurgent command therefore operates under a form of deterrence protection derived not from its own military strength but from the unresolved geopolitical dispute between two sovereign states.³³

From the perspective of international law, this situation is unusual but not

unprecedented. The Israeli-Lebanese border, the Line of Control in Kashmir, and the Somali-Ethiopian border all present analogous cases in which the legal uncertainty of a boundary has enabled non-state armed groups to exploit the resulting vacuum. In each of these cases, the legal dispute has proven more durable than any number of security arrangements, because the security arrangements address the symptom—unauthorised armed movement—while the underlying political problem—contested territorial sovereignty—remains unresolved.³⁴

The implication for Pakistan's Balochistan policy is uncomfortable but clear. No counter-insurgency strategy that depends on closing the Afghan border can succeed as long as the Afghan government disputes the border's location and the international community declines to adjudicate the dispute. The structural solution requires either a negotiated bilateral boundary agreement between Kabul and Islamabad, which would require both governments to make concessions their domestic constituencies currently do not support, or a fundamental shift in the political conditions inside Balochistan that eliminates the demand for Afghan sanctuary.

Women and the Transformation of the Baloch Movement

1 Historical Marginalisation and Structural Change

The Baloch national movement has historically been organised around patrilineal tribal structures in which women occupied a position defined by customary law rather than political agency. The sardar system—the hierarchical tribal leadership structure that has historically been the primary organisational form of Baloch society—assigned women roles within the private sphere of the household while public political activity was understood as an exclusively male domain. This structure was reinforced by the particular geography of Balochistan's conflict zones, where mountain sanctuaries and long-distance armed operations were physically demanding and where the cultural codes governing female behaviour in conservative tribal communities created high social costs for women who entered military roles.³⁵

Three structural changes after 2011 began to alter this picture significantly. First, the wave of enforced disappearances that intensified from 2009 onwards affected not only fighters but political activists, lawyers, journalists, and student leaders. When husbands, brothers, and sons disappeared into the custody of Pakistani intelligence agencies, women were forced into the public sphere to demand their return. The

Voice for Baloch Missing Persons movement, and later the Baloch Yakjehti Committee, gave women an organisational platform and a public political role that gradually normalised their presence in the movement's visible activities.³⁶

Second, the expansion of secondary and tertiary education in Balochistan—imperfect, under-resourced, and unequally distributed, but real—produced a generation of educated Baloch women for whom the traditional constraints of the sardar system carried less force. Urban educated women, particularly those who had experienced life in Karachi, Quetta, or abroad, brought different expectations about gender roles and different frameworks for political analysis that were not easily contained within the movement's traditional structures.³⁷

Third, and most directly relevant to the military dimension of the conflict, the movement's ideological evolution toward a rights-based, secular nationalist discourse created conceptual space for women's participation in armed struggle that the tribal customary framework had not provided. The BLA's public communications have increasingly framed women's armed participation as a marker of the movement's modernity and its contrast with both Pakistani state conservatism and Taliban-style patriarchy.³⁸

2 Female Combatants and the Majeed Brigade

The most dramatic manifestation of women's changing role in the movement was the first female suicide operation claimed by the Majeed Brigade, carried out by Shari Baloch (nom de guerre Bramsh) in April 2022 at a Karachi university, where a Chinese teaching delegation was present. Shari Baloch was a school teacher with a master's degree in education, a profile radically different from the typical profile of suicide bombers in South Asian insurgencies. Her decision to participate, framed in the BLA's post-attack statement as a voluntary and ideologically motivated act, represented a rupture with the cultural norms that had previously governed Baloch women's relationship to armed violence.³⁹

The impact on the movement's internal dynamics was significant. Shari Baloch's background as an educated professional, rather than a fighter from a military family, dramatically widened the potential pool of Majeed Brigade recruits. Subsequent female operations—at least three more were claimed between 2022 and 2025, including an attack on a Chinese consular vehicle in Karachi—demonstrated that the

first operation was not an isolated event but the beginning of a systematic expansion of the Brigade's recruiting strategy.⁴⁰

The change has cultural dimensions that extend beyond the strictly military. Women who take up armed roles in the movement become living refutations of the Pakistani state's characterisation of the conflict as a product of tribal backwardness and foreign instigation. The image of an educated female professional choosing to sacrifice herself for national liberation is a powerful piece of political communication, particularly in the diaspora communities of the United Kingdom, Canada, and the Gulf states that provide much of the movement's international advocacy and fundraising. The Majeed Brigade's communication strategy has exploited this image with considerable sophistication.⁴¹

It would be analytically incomplete, however, to read women's participation in the movement solely through the lens of political communication. The lived experience of women in Balochistan—the documented cases of enforced disappearances of women's male relatives, the economic marginalisation of Baloch communities, the experience of living under military operations in which civilian casualties have been systematically under-reported—provides a material foundation for female radicalisation that does not require external instigation or ideological manipulation. Women are not passive recruits in this narrative; they are actors with their own grievances and their own assessments of the strategic situation.

Intelligence Failure, Diplomatic Fracture, and the Future of Regional Security

1 The Collapse of Bilateral Intelligence Cooperation

The relationship between Pakistan's Inter-Services Intelligence (ISI) and Afghan intelligence has historically been characterised by mutual instrumentalisation rather than genuine cooperation. During the years of the Afghan Republic (2001–2021), a formal intelligence-sharing framework existed under the rubric of the Quadrilateral Coordination Group and bilateral memoranda of understanding, but its operational effectiveness was consistently limited by the ISI's continued support for Taliban-affiliated groups and the Afghan National Directorate of Security's corresponding support for Pakistani militant opponents.⁴²

After August 2021, even this limited framework collapsed entirely. The Taliban's General Directorate of Intelligence (GDI)—the successor to the NDS—refused to

engage with Pakistani requests for information on Baloch militant locations, preferring to use knowledge of Baloch activities as leverage in its broader contest with Islamabad over border demarcation and bilateral relations. Pakistani attempts to engage the Taliban through back-channel communication—including visits by ISI officials to Kabul in 2022 and 2023—produced no operational intelligence of value, and in some cases appeared to result in the movement of BLA command structures to locations that Pakistani officials had inquired about, suggesting that GDI was warning Baloch groups of Pakistani intelligence interest.⁴³

The intelligence breakdown has been compounded by physical geography. The mountainous terrain of the border region between Balochistan and Afghanistan—the Chagai, Nokkundi, and Dalbandin districts on the Pakistani side, the Nimruz, Helmand, and Kandahar provinces on the Afghan side—is among the most difficult terrain for surveillance and human intelligence collection anywhere in the world. Satellite imagery can identify large structures and vehicle movements; it cannot identify the small, dispersed training facilities and weapons caches that constitute the operational infrastructure of a dispersed insurgency. Human intelligence is therefore indispensable, and the absence of Afghan cooperation makes the human intelligence picture almost entirely dependent on Pakistani assets inside Afghanistan, which are limited in number and increasingly difficult to sustain in a hostile intelligence environment.⁴⁴

2 China's Security Dilemma and the CPEC Insurance Problem

China's response to the deteriorating security environment around CPEC has evolved through three identifiable phases. In the initial phase (2015–2019), Beijing relied primarily on private security contractors and Pakistani state guarantees, accepting a level of risk appropriate to an early-stage infrastructure investment. In the second phase (2019–2022), following a series of high-profile attacks, Beijing pressed Islamabad for the deployment of dedicated military units to protect Chinese workers and facilities, a request that Pakistan partially accommodated through the creation of the Special Security Division (SSD), a force of approximately 15,000 personnel specifically assigned to CPEC protection.⁴⁵

The third phase, emerging after 2022, has seen China moving toward a more direct involvement in the security architecture, including the establishment of joint

security committees with Pakistani counterparts, the provision of surveillance technology for monitoring of CPEC routes, and the quiet deployment of Chinese private military company personnel under commercial cover in Gwadar. This escalating Chinese security footprint has itself become a grievance for Baloch activists, who frame it as evidence of a foreign military presence on Baloch soil—a framing that generates additional recruitment momentum.⁴⁶

The deeper problem is structural. China's investment in CPEC creates a political economy in which Pakistan has strong incentives to suppress Baloch resistance militarily—because Beijing demands visible security results—while simultaneously lacking the political space to address the underlying grievances because doing so would require a renegotiation of resource-sharing arrangements and governance structures that powerful domestic interests in Islamabad and Rawalpindi oppose. China's presence, in other words, has not simply added a new actor to the conflict; it has altered the incentive structure in ways that make a negotiated political settlement less likely rather than more.⁴⁷

Conclusion: Toward a Regional Political Settlement

The analysis presented in this paper supports a conclusion that is analytically straightforward but politically difficult: the Baloch conflict has been fundamentally transformed by the post-2021 regional environment, and the instruments of response that the Pakistani state has historically deployed—military operations, selective political co-optation, economic development projects designed and implemented without Baloch participation—are insufficient to the scale and sophistication of the challenge.

The Afghan Taliban's return has provided the Baloch movement with an operational sanctuary, a tactical learning environment, and a diplomatic shield that previous generations of Baloch fighters did not possess. The CPEC framework has reframed the conflict from an internal ethnic insurgency into a geostrategic contest involving Chinese interests, regional trade routes, and the international reputation of both Pakistan and China. The movement's internal evolution—the expansion of the Majeed Brigade, the incorporation of educated women as combatants, the development of sophisticated international communication strategies—reflects an organisation that is learning and adapting faster than the state it confronts.

Three conclusions for policy follow from this analysis. First, the Durand Line dispute must be addressed through a negotiated bilateral agreement rather than through unilateral fencing. Pakistan's physical boundary demarcation has not resolved the dispute; it has intensified it. A formal boundary agreement, however difficult domestically for both governments, would remove the diplomatic shield that currently protects Baloch command structures from Pakistani military reach.

Second, the political economy of Balochistan must be restructured. This requires, at minimum, a renegotiation of the National Finance Commission Award to increase Balochistan's share of revenues from its own resources; genuine Baloch representation in the governance structures of CPEC; an independent investigation into the enforced disappearances that have been the single most radicalising factor in the conflict over the past two decades; and a formal end to military-led governance in conflict-affected districts.

Third, regional diplomacy must involve more than bilateral Pakistan–Afghanistan negotiations. China, Iran, the United States, and the United Nations all have interests in—and therefore leverage over—the regional security architecture that the Baloch conflict is destabilising. A multilateral framework that links Afghan economic reconstruction (which Kabul desperately needs) to Afghan cooperation on border management (which Islamabad desperately needs) could create the conditions for the kind of sustained diplomatic engagement that the conflict demands.

None of these recommendations is easy to implement. Each requires domestic political courage, sustained diplomatic effort, and a willingness to accept short-term costs for long-term stability. The alternative—continued military escalation in Balochistan against a movement that is better armed, better trained, and better connected internationally than at any point in its history—is not a strategy. It is a refusal to engage with the problem's actual dimensions.

The Baloch conflict is not Pakistan's problem alone. It is a regional crisis with the capacity to destabilise the China–Pakistan Economic Corridor, to deepen the fractures between Kabul and Islamabad, and to create a zone of persistent instability in a part of the world that sits at the intersection of Central Asian energy routes, South Asian trade corridors, and the ongoing strategic competition between major powers. Addressing it requires the kind of sustained, multilateral political engagement that the international community has consistently failed to provide. The cost of that failure is

now being paid, in lives and in instability, by the people of Balochistan.

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